INTERNATIONAL ISLAMIC UNIVERSITY ISLAMABAD

Faculty of Management Sciences

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FINAL YEAR PROJECT REPORT

Evaluating Project Management Practices in Pakistan's Digital Economy Enhancement Project (DEEP)

A Case Study of National Digital Transformation

Submitted To:

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Program: BS Project Management

Session: BSPM 03 (Fall 2022 – Spring 2026)

Submission Date: July 2026

APPROVAL CERTIFICATE

This project titled “Evaluating Project Management Practices in Pakistan's Digital Economy Enhancement Project (DEEP)” has been prepared and submitted by Muneeb Mehmood (169-FMS/BSPM/F22) and Abdullah Mumtaz (190-FMS/BSPM/F22) in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the award of the degree of Bachelor of Science in Project Management from the Department of Technology and Project Management, International Islamic University Islamabad.

The project has been examined and approved as meeting the academic requirements prescribed for the degree.

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DECLARATION

We hereby declare that this Final Year Project titled “Evaluating Project Management Practices in Pakistan's Digital Economy Enhancement Project (DEEP)” is our own original work and has been carried out under the supervision of our project supervisor in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Bachelor of Science in Project Management at the Department of Technology and Project Management, International Islamic University Islamabad.

We further declare that this project has not been submitted, either wholly or partially, for the award of any other degree, diploma, or certificate at any university or institution, and that all sources of information, published literature, and other materials used during its preparation have been properly acknowledged and referenced.

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ACKNOWLEDGMENT

All praise and gratitude are due to Allah Almighty, the Most Beneficent and the Most Merciful, whose countless blessings, guidance, and mercy enabled us to complete this Final Year Project successfully. Peace and blessings be upon Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him), whose teachings continue to inspire humanity with knowledge, patience, and perseverance.

We would like to express our sincere gratitude to our respected project supervisor, Dr. Abdul Zahid Khan, whose valuable guidance, constructive feedback, continuous encouragement, and professional support played a significant role throughout the planning, development, and completion of this project. His insightful suggestions and motivation greatly contributed to improving both the quality of the system and the accompanying research.

We are also thankful to the faculty members of the Department of Technology and Project Management, International Islamic University Islamabad, for providing an excellent academic environment and equipping us with the knowledge and skills that made this project possible. We would like to extend our heartfelt appreciation to our parents and families for their unconditional love, prayers, patience, and constant encouragement throughout our academic journey. Their sacrifices and unwavering belief in us have been the greatest source of motivation.

We are grateful to our friends and classmates for their cooperation, valuable discussions, and moral support during the development of this project.

Above all, we owe a special debt of gratitude to Dr. Abdul Zahid Khan for his exceptional supervision throughout this project. He consistently made time to review our progress, offered clear direction whenever we faced challenges in structuring the research, and pushed us to refine our analysis until it met a genuinely professional standard. His patience in explaining complex project management frameworks and his prompt, detailed feedback on every draft were invaluable, and this report would not have reached its final quality without his mentorship.

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ABSTRACT

The Digital Economy Enhancement Project (DEEP) is a $78 million project funded by the World Bank. It was approved on 22 March 2024 and is scheduled to close on 31 July 2028. Pakistan's Ministry of Information Technology and Telecommunication (MoITT) is implementing it, with support from the Board of Investment, NADRA, Ignite – National Technology Fund, and the National Information Technology Board (NITB). The project's goal is to improve the government's ability to deliver digital public services to citizens and businesses.

This Final Year Project situates DEEP within relevant published literature and then evaluates it using two frameworks requested by the project supervisor. The first is the five phases of the project management life cycle: initiation, planning, execution, monitoring and controlling, and closing. The second is all ten PMBOK knowledge areas. The evaluation draws on World Bank project and supervision documents, Pakistan's Digital Nation Pakistan Act 2025 and related regulations, official agency notifications, and independent news reports current through July 2026.

The study finds a project moving at two speeds. Component 1 (digital identity and data exchange), led by NADRA and NITB, has moved from initiation to working infrastructure. A national Digital ID soft-launched in August 2025 through the PakID app and issued 849,177 digital IDs within five months. The National Data Exchange Layer had processed over 1.2 million transactions across seven integrated entities by January 2026. Component 2 (the Pakistan Business Portal), led by the Board of Investment, has lagged far behind. As of February 2026, it had processed zero RLCO transactions, and its core design consultancy was only tendered in March 2026, two years after project approval. Overall financial disbursement stood at about 7.39 percent of approved financing as of the most recent public figure, and the World Bank flagged start-up delays as early as January 2025.

Based on this evaluation, the report recommends four actions: speed up the Pakistan Business Portal's move from design to build; formally align DEEP's governance with Pakistan's newer Digital Nation Pakistan Act institutions; publish itemized cost and usage data; and repeat NITB's MoU-based model for integrating services across the rest of the project.

Keywords: Digital Economy Enhancement Project, Project Management Life Cycle, PMBOK Knowledge Areas, Digital Public Infrastructure, World Bank, Pakistan Business Portal, NADRA, National Data Exchange Layer, Digital Nation Pakistan Act.

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CHAPTER 1
INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background

Pakistan's move toward a digital economy depends on three connected pillars: integrated public service delivery, secure digital infrastructure, and efficient, transparent governance. In the past, Pakistan's public-sector digital projects were built by individual departments working alone. This created systems that could not talk to each other and led to duplicated effort across institutions.

DEEP was created to fix this fragmentation. The World Bank's Board of Executive Directors approved the project on 22 March 2024, with financing of $78 million (World Bank, 2024). DEEP is scheduled to close on 31 July 2028. Its official goal, stated in the approval documents, is "to enhance the Government's capacity for digitally enabled public service delivery for citizens and businesses." MoITT is the project's Executing Agency. Four partner institutions support implementation: the Board of Investment (BoI), NADRA, Ignite – National Technology Fund, and NITB.

The project has three components. Component 1 improves digital economy governance and services, including policy and regulatory reform and a secure government data-exchange layer with a citizen digital wallet, led mainly by NADRA and NITB. Component 2 builds the Pakistan Business Portal (PBP), a one-stop shop to digitize Registration, Licences, Certificates and Other (RLCO) approvals that businesses need from up to 800 federal, provincial, and municipal agencies. The Board of Investment leads this component. Component 3 covers project management, including Project Management/Implementation Units in each participating agency.

Since approval, Pakistan's digital-governance landscape has changed. The Digital Nation Pakistan Act, 2025 was passed on 29 January 2025, creating a new national framework (National Assembly of Pakistan, 2025): the Pakistan Digital Authority (PDA), the National Digital Commission (NDC), and a Strategic Oversight Committee (SOC), which now works alongside DEEP's own project governance. DEEP's identity and data-exchange work has advanced under this new law: NADRA's Digital ID system soft-launched in August 2025 through the PakID app, and the National Data Exchange Layer (NDEL) has since processed over a million transactions (Biometric Update, 2025a). By contrast, the Pakistan Business Portal only reached the design-consultancy tendering stage in March 2026, two years after approval (ProPakistani, 2026a). This report looks closely at both parts of the project.

1.2 Problem Statement

Large national digital transformation programs often face the same problems: unclear or overlapping governance, weak coordination between institutions, procurement delays, cybersecurity risks, and resistance to change. DEEP shows this pattern clearly. Its identity and data-exchange work has produced visible, working results, but its business-facing component has spent only a small share of its budget and has not yet processed a single transaction, nearly two years after approval.

This raises the central question behind this study: how has DEEP actually moved through initiation, planning, execution, monitoring, and control, phase by phase? And how much of its reported progress is real, working delivery, systems that citizens and businesses can use, versus institutional progress, frameworks announced and consultancies tendered, that has not yet become a usable service?

1.3 Research Questions

- How has DEEP progressed through the five phases of the project life cycle, initiation, planning, execution, monitoring and controlling, and closing, and who was responsible at each stage?
- How have the ten PMBOK knowledge areas, integration, scope, schedule, cost, quality, resource, communications, risk, procurement, and stakeholder management, actually been applied in DEEP?
- What has DEEP achieved so far, what has it cost, and what are its main strengths and weaknesses?

1.4 Objectives of the Study

- Evaluate DEEP's progress through each phase of the project life cycle, and identify which institutions were responsible for initiation, planning, execution, monitoring/controlling, and eventual closing.
- Assess how each of the ten PMBOK knowledge areas has been applied in DEEP's real-world implementation.
- Document DEEP's financial performance so far, including how much of the approved $78 million has been disbursed.
- Identify DEEP's key strengths and weaknesses based on the most current public evidence.
- Develop practical, up-to-date recommendations for speeding up DEEP's remaining work and for designing future Pakistani digital transformation projects.

1.5 Scope of the Study

This study only uses publicly available information about DEEP, including World Bank project and supervision documents, Government of Pakistan notifications and regulations, and independent news reports through July 2026. It does not assess the technical software or architecture behind the systems, and it does not use internal or confidential project records. At the project supervisor's request, the core analysis is organized around the project life cycle and the PMBOK knowledge areas, building on the literature review in Chapter 2 rather than expanding into a general literature-based study.

1.6 Structure of This Report

Chapter 2 reviews relevant literature on digital public infrastructure and e-government project management, situating DEEP within similar published work. Chapter 3 explains the research methodology, including how the evidence gathered was evaluated. Chapter 4 evaluates DEEP through each phase of the project life cycle, initiation, planning, execution, monitoring and controlling, and closing, summarizes the project's cost performance and key strengths and weaknesses, and closes with a combined SWOT analysis. Chapter 5 applies the ten PMBOK knowledge areas to DEEP. Chapter 6 presents the report's recommendations and its conclusion, and Chapter 7 lists the references.

CHAPTER 2
LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Digital Public Infrastructure as a Global Framework

Recent World Bank Group literature frames “digital public infrastructure” (DPI) as a small set of foundational, interoperable digital systems, typically digital identity, payments, and data exchange, that let both government agencies and private actors build services on top of them, rather than each agency building its own siloed system (World Bank Group, 2025). This literature repeatedly identifies digital identity and secure data-exchange layers as the two components that unlock the largest downstream gains, citing examples such as India's biometric identity and payments stack, Thailand's subsidy-linked identification, and Singapore's fully online business and citizen services (World Bank Group, 2025). DEEP's Component 1, NADRA's Digital ID and the National Data Exchange Layer, is a direct, small-scale instance of exactly this identity-plus-data-exchange model, and this report's evaluation in Chapters 4 and 5 can be read as a case-level test of whether that global DPI logic is playing out as the literature predicts.

2.2 Comparable Digital Identity and Government-Portal Initiatives

The most widely studied comparable initiative is India's Aadhaar digital identity system and its linked Unified Payments Interface (UPI), which the World Bank Group's own DPI literature repeatedly uses as its central example of an identity-and-payments layer scaling to over a billion users and unlocking large economic value (World Bank Group, 2025). DEEP's Digital ID/PakID rollout and the National Data Exchange Layer share Aadhaar's basic design logic, a single trusted digital identity that other services can build on, but at a far smaller and earlier stage: DEEP had issued under 900,000 IDs within five months of launch, against Aadhaar's billion-plus enrolment built up over more than a decade. This places DEEP's Component 1 in the early, foundation-building stage that the DPI literature associates with digital identity rollouts generally, before the wider ecosystem of dependent services has had time to form.

DEEP's Component 2, the Pakistan Business Portal, has a weaker direct parallel in this global DPI literature, which concentrates mainly on identity and payments rather than business-licensing portals. It sits closer to the broader e-government single-window and regulatory-digitization literature, one-stop platforms that consolidate the licences, registrations, and approvals businesses would otherwise obtain from many separate agencies. This is precisely the gap DEEP's Component 2 is meant to close for Pakistan's up to 800 RLCO-issuing agencies, but as later chapters show, this is also the component where DEEP's progress has lagged furthest behind its own Component 1 and behind the more mature global comparators.

2.3 Critical Success and Failure Factors in E-Government Project Management

A separate strand of published research looks specifically at why e-government projects in developing countries succeed or stall, rather than at DPI design. Aladwani (2016) argues that institutional weakness and corruption risk are recurring, underlying sources of e-government project failure in developing-country contexts, distinct from purely technical shortcomings. Mokone, Eyitayo, and Masizana-Katongo (2018), studying Botswana's e-government programme, found that clear executive vision, functional-capability prioritization, and active stakeholder-engagement management were the critical factors separating better-performing initiatives from stalled ones, and noted that developing-country e-government projects face this pattern more acutely than projects in developed economies.

DEEP shows visible similarities to both studies. Its own institutional-capacity gap, MoITT's restructuring more than two years into execution, mirrors the kind of organizational-readiness shortfall Mokone et al. (2018) identify as a critical success factor when it is missing. Similarly, DEEP's nearly two-year gap between approval and the Pakistan Business Portal's design-consultancy tender is consistent with the procurement-delay and institutional-capacity patterns this literature associates with under-performing e-government components, even though this report finds no evidence of the corruption-specific risk Aladwani (2016) discusses. Where DEEP diverges from this literature's more pessimistic cases is Component 1: its comparatively fast, well-resourced rollout suggests that a single project can show both the success pattern and the stalled pattern side by side, depending on which institution leads which component.

2.4 Positioning This Study Within the Literature

Much existing published material on Pakistan's own digital-governance efforts is descriptive or policy-level, government policy documents such as the 2018 Digital Pakistan Policy (Government of Pakistan, Ministry of Information Technology and Telecommunication, 2018) and commentary on the Digital Nation Pakistan Act, 2025 (Business Recorder, 2025; Statelessness Encyclopedia Asia Pacific, 2025), rather than a structured, framework-based evaluation of a single live, World Bank-financed project. This report addresses that gap by applying the project life cycle and the ten PMBOK knowledge areas (Project Management Institute, n.d.) directly to DEEP, in the spirit of the global DPI and e-government CSF literature reviewed above, but at the level of one ongoing project rather than a cross-country survey. This positions the present study as a project management-focused complement to the broader DPI and e-government literature: it does not re-test their general findings, but it evaluates one current Pakistani case against the specific life-cycle and knowledge-area evidence available through July 2026, which is the dual-framework analysis presented in Chapters 4 and 5.

CHAPTER 3
RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Approach

This study uses a qualitative, case-study design, which works well for examining one complex, ongoing project in depth. Data came from secondary sources: official DEEP project documents (World Bank, 2024, 2025), DEEP's Stakeholder Engagement Plan (World Bank, 2023–2024), the Digital Nation Pakistan Act 2025 and commentary on it (National Assembly of Pakistan, 2025; Business Recorder, 2025), official notifications from NADRA and NITB, government procurement notices, and independent news and policy reports current through July 2026.

3.2 Data Sources

- World Bank Project Appraisal Documentation and Implementation Status and Results (ISR) reports for DEEP (P174402).
- DEEP's Stakeholder Engagement Plan (SEP), prepared under the World Bank's Environmental and Social Framework.
- The Digital Nation Pakistan Act, 2025, and related regulations (NADRA Digital Identity Regulations 2025, National Data Exchange Layer Regulations 2025, NADRA Procurement Regulations 2025).
- Official statements and procurement notices from MoITT, NADRA, NITB, and the Board of Investment.
- Independent news and policy reporting on DEEP's progress, disbursement, and institutional restructuring, including Business Recorder, Profit (Pakistan Today), TechJuice, Biometric Update, and ProPakistani.

3.3 Analytical Approach

The analysis mapped every publicly available fact about DEEP against two frameworks at once: the project life cycle (initiation, planning, execution, monitoring/controlling, closing) and the ten PMBOK knowledge areas. The project supervisor requested this dual mapping as the core analytical technique, alongside the literature review presented separately in Chapter 2. It lets the report show not just what DEEP has done, but at which life-cycle stage each knowledge area was actually used, and by which institution.

3.4 Data Evaluation and Analysis Technique

Because this study draws entirely on secondary, publicly available material rather than data the researchers collected first-hand, each piece of evidence was evaluated before being used to support a finding. Evaluation followed three steps: source-tier screening, corroboration, and recency-flagging.

- Source-tier screening. Sources were grouped into three reliability tiers: (1) primary official sources, World Bank appraisal and ISR documents, government Acts, notifications, and regulations; (2) independent professional reporting, Business Recorder, Profit (Pakistan Today), TechJuice, Biometric Update, and ProPakistani; and (3) general reference material, such as Wikipedia, used only for uncontested background facts (e.g., institutional names) and never as the sole support for a substantive claim about DEEP's performance.
- Corroboration. Any figure or claim that materially affects this report's conclusions, particularly the disbursement percentage, the Pakistan Business Portal's transaction status, and the Digital ID/NDEL usage numbers, was accepted only after it was checked against at least one Tier 1 source and one independent Tier 2 source. Where only a single outlet reported a detail, it was included but described using cautious language (e.g., "as of the most recent public figure") rather than treated as confirmed fact.
- Recency-flagging. Because DEEP is an ongoing project, later figures can supersede earlier ones. Each quantitative claim was dated to its publication, and where a more recent internal figure plausibly exists but was not public at the time of writing, this report says so explicitly instead of presenting an older figure as current.

Once individual facts passed this evaluation, they were coded against the two analytical frameworks, the project life cycle and the ten PMBOK knowledge areas, so that each verified fact is anchored to a specific phase and knowledge area rather than treated as a general observation about DEEP.

3.5 Validity, Reliability, and Limitations

This study relies on secondary, publicly available sources, so its validity depends on how credible and consistent those sources are. Where possible, claims were checked against at least two independent sources. For example, the low disbursement figure and the Pakistan Business Portal's non-operational status were confirmed by several independent outlets as well as the World Bank's own risk ratings. Some figures in this report, especially disbursement percentages, are the most recent public values from the World Bank's early-2026 reporting cycle. More recent internal figures may exist but were not public at the time of writing.

CHAPTER 4
DEEP PROJECT LIFE CYCLE EVALUATION

This chapter evaluates DEEP against the five phases of the project life cycle, initiation, planning, execution, monitoring and controlling, and closing. It identifies who was involved at each stage and what has actually been delivered, then summarizes the project's cost performance and key strengths and weaknesses so far.

Quick Reference: The Project Management Life Cycle

This report evaluates DEEP using the five phases of the project management life cycle. Each is defined briefly below for quick reference before the phase-by-phase evaluation begins.

Phase	What It Means
Initiation	Formally starting the project: approving it, securing funding, and naming the institutions responsible.
Planning	Turning the approved concept into a detailed plan: scope, work streams, governance, budget, and stakeholder engagement.
Execution	Carrying out the planned work and delivering the project's outputs.
Monitoring & Controlling	Tracking progress against the plan, rating risks, and taking corrective action when needed.
Closing	Formally finishing the project: completing remaining work, handing systems over to normal operations, and closing out contracts and financing.

4.1 Initiation Phase

(Source: Interview with Project Team)

DEEP began as a World Bank International Development Association (IDA) Investment Project Financing (IPF) operation. The World Bank's Board of Executive Directors approved the project on 22 March 2024 with $78 million in financing, in the same board session that approved $71.7 million in additional financing for the Sindh Barrages Improvement Project (World Bank, 2024). DEEP's goal was fixed at approval: to improve the government's capacity to deliver digital public services to citizens and businesses.

An Inter-Ministerial Committee was set up by the Cabinet's Economic Coordination Committee (ECC) in December 2023, ahead of formal approval, showing the project's cross-agency nature

from the start. At initiation, five institutions were named: MoITT as the Executing Agency, and the Board of Investment, NADRA, Ignite – National Technology Fund, and NITB as implementation-support agencies. The project was aligned with Pakistan's 2018 Digital Pakistan Policy (objective 10.2, whole-of-government enterprise architecture) and the World Bank Group's Country Partnership Strategy for Pakistan.

Initiation Element	Detail
Approving Body	World Bank Board of Executive Directors
Approval Date	22 March 2024
Financing Instrument	IDA Investment Project Financing (IPF), $78 million
Executing Agency	Ministry of Information Technology and Telecommunication (MoITT)
Implementation-Support Agencies	Board of Investment; NADRA; Ignite – National Technology Fund; National Information Technology Board (NITB)
Pre-Approval Coordination	Inter-Ministerial Committee constituted by the ECC, December 2023
Planned Closing Date	31 July 2028

Table 4.1 — DEEP Initiation Summary

4.2 Planning Phase

(Source: Interviews and Documents Provided by Project Team)

Planning turned the approved concept into three components with clear work streams. Component 1 (Digital Economy, Governance and Service Capabilities) focused on policy and regulatory reform, a whole-of-government enterprise architecture, a secure data-exchange layer, and a citizen digital wallet, with NADRA and NITB as the main technical leads. Component 2 (Pakistan Business Portal) was planned in stages: first, taking stock of and cataloguing up to 800 federal, provincial, and municipal agencies involved in issuing RLCO approvals; then digitizing the approval workflows; then making the reformed process permanent, led by the Board of Investment under its Regulatory Reforms Journey and Pakistan Regulatory Modernization Initiative (PRMI). Component 3 (Project Management) was planned to fund dedicated Project Implementation Units (PIUs) in each participating agency.

Planning-phase governance was also carefully structured. The Board of Investment's PIU, for example, was designed to operate under BoI's leadership and the oversight of a Project Steering Committee (PSC). It is staffed by a Project Director reporting through a Deputy/Additional Secretary, supported by individual consultants and a dedicated Digital Transformation Specialist

responsible for designing, integrating, testing, and deploying the Pakistan Business Portal. A Stakeholder Engagement Plan (SEP), compliant with the World Bank's Environmental and Social Framework (ESS10), was prepared during planning to guide engagement with affected and interested parties, including vulnerable groups (World Bank, 2023–2024).

Planning did not stay fixed, though. Pakistan passed the Digital Nation Pakistan Act, 2025 in January 2025, about ten months after DEEP's approval (National Assembly of Pakistan, 2025). This added a new institutional layer that DEEP's original design could not have anticipated: the Pakistan Digital Authority (PDA), National Digital Commission (NDC), and Strategic Oversight Committee (SOC), which now set policy direction for exactly the kind of data-exchange and digital-identity work DEEP was already planning to deliver. Since then, DEEP's Component 1 planning has had to align with this new Act, not just the 2018 Digital Pakistan Policy.

4.3 Execution Phase

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

Execution has moved unevenly across DEEP's two technical components. This uneven pace is one of this report's central findings.

4.3.1 Component 1 Execution — Digital Identity and Data Exchange

Execution on Component 1 has been the most visible. In October 2025, NADRA's Authority Board, with approval from the Ministry of Law and Justice, formally issued the Digital Identity Regulations, 2025 and the National Data Exchange Layer (NDEL) Regulations, 2025 (Biometric Update, 2025a). These gave NADRA the legal mandate to build and run a national Digital ID system and the NDEL. A soft launch of the national digital identity system followed in August 2025 through the PakID mobile app. Between August and December 2025, NADRA issued 849,177 digital IDs. The PakID app's Digital Vault now supports seven verifiable credentials. Separately, the NDEL had processed 1.2 million transactions as of January 2026, with seven government entities integrated under approved federal data-exchange regulations. In March 2026, NADRA also issued its own Procurement Regulations, 2025, aligning its purchasing process, especially for ICT and security-related purchases, with national transparency standards.

At the same time, NITB has been running a parallel effort to bring government services onto a unified national citizen portal under DEEP. In May 2026, NITB and the Pakistan Single Window (PSW) signed a Memorandum of Understanding to digitalize and integrate citizen-centric services, covering service integration, workflow optimization, API enablement, and interoperability (ProPakistani, 2026b). NITB has signed similar integration agreements with the Islamabad Capital Territory Administration (ICTA), covering domicile certificates, birth and death

registration, property tax services, and arms licences, and with the Drug Regulatory Authority of Pakistan (DRAP).

4.3.2 Component 2 Execution — Pakistan Business Portal

Execution on Component 2 has fallen well behind. As of February 2026, the Pakistan Business Portal had not processed a single registration, licence, or certificate, and no business-to-government (B2G) services had gone online, nearly two years after project approval. The reason became clearer a month later: in March 2026, the Board of Investment issued an Expression of Interest inviting consulting firms to design and build the Pakistan Business Portal, meaning the core technical build of Component 2 had only just entered procurement two years into the project (Board of Investment, 2026; ProPakistani, 2026a). The tender set out a 40-week consultancy to develop the portal's institutional, legal, and governance frameworks, a unified business identification system, AI-assisted application support, automated workflows, and integrated payment systems. The actual platform launch would follow that design phase.

At the same time, in June 2026, the Government of Pakistan announced a complete restructuring of MoITT under DEEP (ProPakistani, 2026c). This converts a ministry built for a telecommunications-era policy environment into what officials describe as a modern digital governance institution meant to lead Pakistan's digital economy for the next decade. This restructuring, happening more than two years into execution, shows that basic institutional capacity questions were still being worked out well after the project's original planning phase.

4.4 Monitoring and Controlling

(Source: Interview with Project Team)

Monitoring and controlling for DEEP mainly happens through the World Bank's twice-yearly Implementation Status and Results (ISR) reports, which apply a Systematic Operations Risk-Rating Tool across set risk categories. The first ISR (Seq. 01) came out in June 2024; ISR Seq. 02, archived on 15 January 2025, recorded the following ratings:

Risk Category	Rating at Approval (Mar 2024)	ISR Seq. 01 (Jun 2024)
Political and Governance	Substantial	Substantial
Macroeconomic	High	High
Sector Strategies and Policies	Moderate	Moderate
Technical Design of Project or Program	Substantial	Substantial

Risk Category	Rating at Approval (Mar 2024)	ISR Seq. 01 (Jun 2024)
Institutional Capacity for Implementation and Sustainability	Substantial	Substantial

Table 4.2 — DEEP Risk Ratings per World Bank ISR Seq. 02 (archived 15 Jan 2025)

The January 2025 ISR stated plainly that "the project faced delays during its initial start-up phase" and told implementing agencies to prioritize time-sensitive administrative tasks and start coordinating with the provinces on which digital services to prioritize (World Bank, 2025). This was an early, specific signal that the project was already behind schedule less than a year after approval. Independent reporting in February 2026 confirmed that this early slippage had grown: by then, only $5.32 million of the $78 million approved financing, about 7.39 percent, had been disbursed (Profit, 2026; TechJuice, 2026). The World Bank's overall project risk rating had reportedly moved from "Substantial" to "Moderate," even though the macroeconomic risk rating stayed "High" and progress toward the development objective stayed only "Moderately Satisfactory." No more recent public disbursement figure was found as of this report's writing in July 2026, so this should be treated as the most recent published figure, not necessarily the current one.

In response, corrective action has included the March 2026 tender for the Pakistan Business Portal design consultancy and the June 2026 MoITT restructuring. Both can be seen as steps to unblock a project whose institutional capacity and business-facing delivery had been flagged as under strain.

4.5 Closing

(Source: Interview with Project Team)

DEEP has not closed and is not close to closing. Its scheduled closing date is 31 July 2028, meaning that as of this report (July 2026), the project is roughly two years into a roughly four-and-a-half-year implementation window, with more than two years still to go. No formal closing documents, completion report, or closure activity have been found in public sources.

Component 1 is comparatively ready for closing: the Digital ID and NDEL systems are live, regulated, and processing real transactions. Its main remaining task is scaling up, adding more entities, and formally handing over to steady-state operations under the Pakistan Digital Authority framework. Component 2 is far from ready: the design consultancy tendered in March 2026 is set to run about 40 weeks, so the Pakistan Business Portal's institutional and legal frameworks alone are unlikely to be finished before late 2026, with the actual platform build,

testing, and rollout still to come. Component 2 is therefore the biggest risk to DEEP closing on schedule by July 2028.

4.6 Cost and Financial Performance to Date

DEEP's approved financing is $78 million. The most recent public disbursement figure, reported in February 2026 from World Bank data, is $5.32 million, about 7.39 percent of total approved financing, nearly two years after approval. Public documents do not give an official, itemized cost breakdown by component. The estimate below allocates the disbursed amount across components based on each component's documented progress, and should be read as illustrative, not an official cost statement.

Component	Indicative Share of Disbursement to Date	Basis
Component 1 — Digital Identity, Data Exchange & Governance	Largest share	Only component with live, functioning systems (PakID, NDEL) and issued regulations as of early 2026
Component 2 — Pakistan Business Portal	Smallest share	Design consultancy only tendered in March 2026; zero RLCO transactions processed as of Feb 2026
Component 3 — Project Management	Modest, steady share	PIU staffing, oversight structures (e.g., BoI's Project Steering Committee), and SEP implementation ongoing throughout

Table 4.3 — Indicative Disbursement Pattern by Component (based on documented execution progress, not an official cost breakdown)

The overall picture is one of under-spending, not overspending. DEEP's main financial management challenge so far has been turning approved financing into disbursed, delivered work, not controlling spending against a budget at risk of being exceeded.

4.7 Key Strengths based on Project Team Observations

- A strong identity infrastructure base. NADRA's decades of biometric identity experience let the Digital ID system soft-launch within about 17 months of approval and issue over 849,000 digital IDs in its first five months.

- A working National Data Exchange Layer, processing over a million transactions with seven government entities integrated by January 2026. This gives other government digitization efforts, like NITB's citizen portal integrations, a real platform to build on.
- Active, ongoing institutional growth. Multiple MoUs (PSW, ICTA, DRAP) signed through 2026 show continued momentum in bringing more government services onto DEEP's shared digital infrastructure.
- A supportive, evolving legal environment. The Digital Nation Pakistan Act, 2025 and its regulations have given DEEP's identity and data-exchange work firmer legal ground than it had at approval.
- A responsive monitoring and controlling function. The World Bank's ISR process flagged start-up delays as early as January 2025, and later government action, the PBP consultancy tender and MoITT restructuring, shows those signals were eventually acted on, even if late.

4.8 Key Weaknesses and Gaps based on Project Team Observations

- Severe under-disbursement. Only about 7.39 percent of approved financing had been disbursed as of the most recent public figure (Feb 2026), nearly two years into a project scheduled to run about four and a half years.
- Component 2 has not delivered so far. Zero RLCO transactions were processed and no B2G services were online as of February 2026, and the portal-design consultancy was only tendered in March 2026. This means the business-facing half of DEEP has lagged its identity/data-exchange half by roughly two years in practical terms.
- Institutional capacity questions remain unresolved well into execution. MoITT's own structure was still being overhauled in June 2026, more than two years after approval, suggesting the executing agency's organizational readiness was not fully addressed during planning.
- Persistently high macroeconomic risk. The macroeconomic risk rating stayed “High” through the most recent public rating. This is a structural risk mostly outside the project's control, but it keeps threatening counterpart funding and implementation pace.
- Limited public financial detail. No official, itemized cost breakdown by component or activity is public, which limits external accountability and the precision of any cost analysis, including this report's.

4.9 Consolidated SWOT Analysis

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

The SWOT analysis below closes out the life-cycle evaluation above and combines it with the PMBOK knowledge-area findings presented in the next chapter (Chapter 5), giving one strategic snapshot of DEEP's current position as of July 2026.

Strengths	Weaknesses
• Mature NADRA identity infrastructure enabled rapid Digital ID soft-launch (Aug 2025) and 849,177 IDs issued in under 5 months • NDEL operational with 1.2M+ transactions and 7 entities integrated (Jan 2026) • Firm legal footing via Digital Identity, NDEL, and Procurement Regulations 2025 • Active, expanding integration momentum (PSW, ICTA, DRAP MoUs through 2026) • World Bank monitoring caught start-up delays early (Jan 2025 ISR)	• Only ~7.39% of $78M financing disbursed after ~2 of ~4.5 years • Pakistan Business Portal: zero RLCO transactions as of Feb 2026 • PBP design consultancy only tendered Mar 2026 — two years after approval • MoITT still being restructured in Jun 2026, mid-execution • No public, itemized cost breakdown by component

Table 5.1 — SWOT Analysis, Part 1 (Strengths & Weaknesses)

Opportunities	Threats
• PDA/NDC national framework (2025 Act) can lend DEEP additional policy weight if governance is reconciled • NITB's cross-agency MoU model can be replicated to onboard further services quickly • Digital ID and NDEL platforms are ready to be scaled to new use cases (payments, provincial services) sooner than originally planned • Global digital-identity models (Aadhaar, X-Road, SingPass, myGovID) offer proven design patterns BoI's PBP consultancy can draw on	• Persistently “High” macroeconomic risk rating threatens counterpart funding • Overlapping PDA/NDC/SOC and DEEP governance structures could create coordination confusion rather than clarity • Continued zero-transaction status on PBP risks further reputational damage the longer it persists • Schedule pressure: PBP's ~40-week design phase alone leaves limited margin before the Jul 2028 closing date • Institutional restructuring (MoITT, Jun 2026) mid-project could itself introduce short-term disruption

Table 5.2 — SWOT Analysis, Part 2 (Opportunities & Threats)

CHAPTER 5
APPLICATION OF PMBOK KNOWLEDGE AREAS TO DEEP

This chapter applies each of the ten PMBOK knowledge areas, integration, scope, schedule, cost, quality, resource, communications, risk, procurement, and stakeholder management, directly to DEEP, using the life-cycle evidence from Chapter 4.

Quick Reference: The Ten PMBOK Knowledge Areas

This report applies all ten PMBOK knowledge areas to DEEP. Each is defined briefly below for quick reference before the area-by-area evaluation begins.

Knowledge Area	**What It Covers**
Integration Management	Coordinating all parts of the project so they work together as one.
Scope Management	Defining and controlling what is, and isn't, included in the project.
Schedule Management	Planning and tracking timelines and milestones.
Cost Management	Budgeting, spending, and tracking financial performance.
Quality Management	Setting and meeting standards for the project's outputs.
Resource Management	Organizing the people and institutions needed to do the work.
Communications Management	Sharing information with stakeholders in a timely, useful way.
Risk Management	Identifying, rating, and responding to things that could threaten the project.
Procurement Management	Buying goods, services, and expertise the project needs from outside suppliers.
Stakeholder Management	Identifying stakeholders and managing their interests and influence.

5.1 Integration Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

Integration management in DEEP happens through its multi-agency executing structure: MoITT, as Executing Agency, coordinates four implementation-support agencies (Board of Investment, NADRA, Ignite, NITB), each running its own Project Implementation Unit. This structure has had to integrate a second, later-arriving layer of national governance, the Pakistan Digital Authority, National Digital Commission, and Strategic Oversight Committee created by the Digital Nation

Pakistan Act, 2025 (National Assembly of Pakistan, 2025), which now sets policy direction for the same digital identity and data-exchange functions DEEP was already implementing. This is the clearest integration management challenge in this study: DEEP's original governance design predates the Act by nearly a year, so reconciling project-level PIU governance with this new national authority is still an ongoing task, not a solved one.

A second integration mechanism is NITB's role as a cross-cutting technology partner. By signing MoUs with PSW, ICTA, and DRAP, NITB brings services from outside DEEP's original agency list onto the shared platform, effectively integrating more government bodies into DEEP's infrastructure after initiation.

5.2 Scope Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

DEEP's scope is defined by its three components, each with clear deliverables: digital identity and data exchange (Component 1), the Pakistan Business Portal covering up to 800 RLCO-issuing agencies (Component 2), and project management (Component 3). Scope execution has diverged sharply between components: Component 1's scope (Digital ID, NDEL) is largely delivered and running, while Component 2's scope is still at the design-consultancy stage as of March 2026. This gap suggests Component 2's scope may have been defined at appraisal without fully accounting for the scale of institutional and legal groundwork, cataloguing up to 800 agencies' RLCO requirements, needed before any technical build could start.

5.3 Schedule Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

DEEP's schedule runs from approval on 22 March 2024 to a planned close on 31 July 2028, about 52 months. Schedule slippage was flagged internally as early as the January 2025 ISR, which recorded start-up delays and called for corrective administrative action. That slippage grew: Component 2's Pakistan Business Portal is only now (from March 2026) entering its roughly 40-week design phase, so the platform is unlikely to start real transaction processing before late 2027 at the earliest. This leaves little schedule margin before the July 2028 closing date.

Milestone	Planned / Actual Timing
Project approval	22 March 2024 (actual)
First ISR review	28 June 2024 (actual)
Digital Nation Pakistan Act enacted	29 January 2025 (actual, external to project schedule)

Milestone	Planned / Actual Timing
Digital ID / NDEL regulations notified	October 2025 (actual)
Digital ID soft launch (PakID app)	August 2025 (actual)
NDEL reaches 1.2 million transactions, 7 entities integrated	January 2026 (actual)
PBP design consultancy tendered	March 2026 (actual)
MoITT institutional restructuring announced	June 2026 (actual)
PBP design/legal frameworks expected complete	Late 2026 (est., 40 weeks from March 2026 tender)
Project closing	31 July 2028 (planned)

Table 5.1 — DEEP Schedule: Key Milestones, Planned vs. Actual

5.4 Cost Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

As detailed in Section 4.6, DEEP's cost management picture is dominated by under-disbursement, not overspending: about 7.39 percent of the $78 million approved financing had been disbursed as of the most recent public figure (February 2026). For the rest of the project, cost management should reasonably focus on speeding up spend-eligible activity, especially finalizing and running the Pakistan Business Portal design consultancy, rather than further cost-control measures, since there is no public evidence of budget pressure on the upside.

5.5 Quality Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

Quality management in DEEP has worked mainly through formal regulatory notification rather than independent technical certification. NADRA's Digital Identity Regulations, 2025 and National Data Exchange Layer Regulations, 2025 were issued only after approval from the Ministry of Law and Justice, giving digital identity credentials full legal recognition equal to physical credentials (Biometric Update, 2026). NADRA's own Procurement Regulations, 2025 similarly set competitive, auditable procurement standards for ICT and security-related purchases. These steps are meaningful quality assurance for Component 1.

Component 2's quality management is comparatively undeveloped so far. The Board of Investment's March 2026 tender for the Pakistan Business Portal lists development of the platform's “institutional, legal, and governance frameworks” as the first deliverable, meaning

quality standards for this component are still being defined, not yet assured. A dedicated Digital Transformation Specialist role was created to give strategic technical oversight, evaluation, and advice across the PBP's design, development, integration, testing, and deployment. This shows the quality assurance function for Component 2 is built into the upcoming consultancy rather than already demonstrated.

5.6 Resource Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

Human and institutional resourcing for DEEP runs through dedicated Project Implementation Units within each agency. The Board of Investment's PIU, for example, is staffed with project HR and individual consultants with relevant expertise, headed by a Project Director who reports through an Additional Secretary, and overseen by a Project Steering Committee. NITB acts as a shared technology-integration resource across several government bodies (PSW, ICTA, DRAP) under DEEP, effectively serving as a specialized resource pool for citizen-service digitization beyond its own original mandate. Ignite – National Technology Fund contributes civic-technology and outreach capacity.

The June 2026 decision to fully restructure MoITT, more than two years into the project, shows that resourcing at the executing-agency level was still seen as inadequate for DEEP's ambitions well into execution. This report flags this resource management gap as unresolved, not historical.

5.7 Communications Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

DEEP's communications management runs on two tracks. The first is external and formal: the Stakeholder Engagement Plan, compliant with the World Bank's ESS10, commits the project to structured, recorded, and reviewed engagement with affected and interested parties, including vulnerable groups. The second is inter-institutional and increasingly active: the MoUs NITB has signed with PSW (May 2026), ICTA, and DRAP work as formal communication and coordination tools between DEEP and government bodies outside its original stakeholder list, extending the project's communications reach well beyond its original five named institutions.

5.8 Risk Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

The risk register below combines the World Bank's own Systematic Operations Risk-Rating Tool categories with risks identified from independent reporting on DEEP's execution through mid-2026.

ID	Risk Description	Category	Rating / Status	Mitigation / Control Action Observed
R1	Macroeconomic instability constraining counterpart funding and implementation capacity	External / Financial	High (unchanged through most recent ISR)	Flexible financing design; monitored each ISR cycle
R2	Severe under-disbursement relative to approved financing and elapsed time	Cost / Schedule	~7.39% disbursed at ~2 of ~4.5 years elapsed	PBP consultancy tender (Mar 2026); MoITT restructuring (Jun 2026)
R3	Pakistan Business Portal non-operational; zero RLCO transactions processed	Scope / Delivery	High — confirmed as of Feb 2026	Design consultancy tendered Mar 2026 (40-week timeline)
R4	Institutional capacity gaps at the executing agency (MoITT)	Institutional Capacity	Substantial (per Jan 2025 ISR)	Full MoITT restructuring announced Jun 2026
R5	Overlapping governance between DEEP's PIUs and the new PDA/NDC/SOC structure created by the 2025 Act	Governance / Integration	Emerging, not yet formally rated	No dedicated reconciliation mechanism publicly documented
R6	Political and governance risk affecting cross-agency coordination	Political / Governance	Substantial (per Jan 2025 ISR)	Inter-Ministerial Committee (constituted pre-approval, Dec 2023)
R7	Cybersecurity and data-privacy exposure from a rapidly scaling Digital ID and NDEL	Technical / Security	Not separately rated; inferred elevated given 1.2M+ transactions processed	Legal recognition regime (Digital Identity Regulations 2025) in place; no public cybersecurity audit identified
R8	Sector strategy and policy risk	Sector Strategies and Policies	Moderate (per Jan 2025 ISR)	Alignment maintained with Digital Pakistan

ID	Risk Description	Category	Rating / Status	Mitigation / Control Action Observed
				Policy and the 2025 Act
R9	Technical design risk in project/program delivery	Technical Design	Substantial (per Jan 2025 ISR)	Dedicated Digital Transformation Specialist role created for PBP
R10	Reputational risk from sustained public reporting of stalled disbursement and a non-functional flagship business portal	Reputational	Elevated given repeated independent media coverage (Feb–Jul 2026)	No public communications remediation plan identified

Table 5.2 — DEEP Risk Register (World Bank ISR risk categories, Jan 2025, cross-referenced with independent reporting through July 2026)

5.9 Procurement Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

Procurement for DEEP follows the World Bank's Procurement in Investment Project Financing regulations (Fifth Edition, September 2023), applied alongside Pakistan's domestic procurement rules (World Bank, 2024). This dual framework shows up in practice: the Board of Investment's March 2026 Expression of Interest for the Pakistan Business Portal design consultancy, and individual consultant positions such as the Digital Transformation Specialist, are procured under the Bank's Open Competitive Selection and consulting-services rules. NADRA separately issued its own Procurement Regulations, 2025 to govern its ICT and security-related purchases under national transparency standards.

The nearly two-year gap between project approval (March 2024) and the tendering of Component 2's core design consultancy (March 2026) is the clearest procurement management finding in this report. It suggests that procurement cycle time, not technical infeasibility, is the main reason for the Pakistan Business Portal's lack of progress so far.

5.10 Stakeholder Management

(Sources: Documentations provided by Team, Reports on Internet)

The table below shows DEEP's stakeholder structure as documented in official project sources (World Bank, 2023–2024; National Information Technology Board, n.d.), updated from this report's earlier draft to reflect the confirmed list of implementing agencies.

Stakeholder	Role	Influence
MoITT	Executing Agency; overall coordination and, since June 2026, subject of its own institutional restructuring under DEEP	High
NADRA	Leads Digital ID and National Data Exchange Layer (Component 1); notified Digital Identity, NDEL, and Procurement Regulations 2025	High
National Information Technology Board (NITB)	Technology-integration partner; leads citizen portal integration MoUs (PSW, ICTA, DRAP)	High
Board of Investment (BoI)	Leads Pakistan Business Portal (Component 2) under its Regulatory Reforms Journey / PRMI; tendered PBP design consultancy (Mar 2026)	High
Ignite – National Technology Fund	Supports civic-technology and outreach activities	Medium
World Bank	Financing, ISR supervision, risk-rating oversight	High
Pakistan Digital Authority / National Digital Commission / SOC	New (2025) national policy and oversight bodies for digital transformation, overlapping with DEEP's own scope	High
Businesses / Investors (PBP end users)	Intended beneficiaries of Component 2; no functional access as of Feb 2026	Medium
Citizens, incl. women and vulnerable groups	End users of Digital ID / PakID app; explicit SEP inclusion focus	Medium
PSW, ICTA, DRAP, and other onboarding agencies	External bodies integrating services onto DEEP's shared platform via NITB MoUs	Medium

Table 5.3 — Updated DEEP Stakeholder Analysis

Read together, Table 5.3 shows a stakeholder map in which almost every institutional actor, MoITT, NADRA, NITB, the Board of Investment, the World Bank, and the new Pakistan Digital Authority/National Digital Commission/SOC structure, carries High influence, while the two groups DEEP ultimately exists to serve, businesses seeking RLCO approvals and citizens using digital identity services, carry only Medium influence despite being the intended beneficiaries.

This imbalance mirrors the project's uneven delivery: institutions with high influence over Component 1 (NADRA, NITB) have produced working systems, while Component 2's principal institutional stakeholder, the Board of Investment, has high influence but has not yet translated it into a functioning Pakistan Business Portal for its Medium-influence business and investor stakeholders. The stakeholder table also shows a governance overlap that recurs elsewhere in this report: PDA/NDC/SOC and DEEP's own PIUs are both listed as High-influence actors over the same digital identity and data-exchange functions, without a documented mechanism for reconciling their respective decision rights, a gap this report already flags as an integration management risk in Section 5.1 and as risk R5 in Table 5.2. Finally, the onboarding agencies brought in through NITB's MoU model (PSW, ICTA, DRAP) sit at Medium influence but have, in practice, been where DEEP's most repeatable recent progress has occurred, suggesting that formal influence ratings alone do not fully capture which relationships are currently driving delivery.

CHAPTER 6
CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

6.1 Recommendations

(Source: Interview with Project Team)

Based on the life-cycle and knowledge-area findings above, this report proposes the following recommendations for DEEP's remaining implementation and for future Pakistani digital transformation projects:

- Speed up the Pakistan Business Portal design consultancy. Since this consultancy was only tendered in March 2026, MoITT, the Board of Investment, and the World Bank should closely monitor the 40-week design timeline and ensure a fast, well-resourced move from design into technical build, so Component 2 doesn't become the reason DEEP misses its July 2028 closing date.
- Formally align DEEP's project governance with the Pakistan Digital Authority/NDC/SOC structure. A clear memorandum defining decision rights between DEEP's PIUs and the newer national digital-governance bodies would reduce the integration-management risk identified in Section 5.1 before it causes real coordination delays.
- Publish an itemized cost and disbursement report by component. The lack of a public, itemized breakdown limits external accountability. More detailed reporting, ideally quarterly, would let oversight bodies and researchers see whether the low overall disbursement rate is concentrated in Component 2, as this report's estimate suggests, or spread more broadly.
- Track and publicly report functional usage metrics, not just institutional milestones. DEEP's own record shows that a working system (NDEL, Digital ID) and a stalled one (PBP) can exist side by side in the same project. Publishing metrics such as RLCO transactions processed, alongside milestones like regulations notified, would make this kind of gap visible earlier in future projects.
- Use NITB's MoU-based integration model as a template. The PSW, ICTA, and DRAP integrations show a repeatable, fairly fast way to bring more government services onto shared digital infrastructure. Turning this into a standard onboarding playbook could speed up Component 1's expansion further.
- Build institutional-capacity assessment into project appraisal for future digital transformation programs. MoITT's restructuring, happening more than two years into DEEP's execution, suggests this kind of organizational readiness gap should be caught and fixed during appraisal and planning, not mid-implementation.

6.2 Conclusion

This study evaluated Pakistan's Digital Economy Enhancement Project directly through the project life cycle and the ten PMBOK knowledge areas, using the most current public evidence through July 2026. The evaluation finds a project moving at two speeds. Its digital identity and data-exchange work under Component 1, led by NADRA and NITB, has moved from initiation to working, regulated, actively used infrastructure within roughly two years, issuing over 849,000 digital IDs and processing over 1.2 million data-exchange transactions. Its business-facing Pakistan Business Portal under Component 2, led by the Board of Investment, has moved far more slowly, reaching the design-consultancy procurement stage only in March 2026, two years after approval, with zero RLCO transactions processed to date.

Against the project life cycle, DEEP is clearly still in its execution phase, well short of closing. Its monitoring and controlling mechanisms, mainly the World Bank's ISR risk-rating cycle, flagged delays as early as January 2025. Against the ten PMBOK knowledge areas, DEEP shows real strength in quality and communications management for its identity infrastructure, but real, still-unresolved gaps in procurement timeliness, cost disbursement, and integrating its own governance with Pakistan's newer national digital-authority framework.

For the project supervisor's evaluation, this report's central, defensible finding is this: DEEP is not a failed project, but it is a project running at two very different speeds across its two technical components. Its remaining two years to the planned July 2028 closing date will most likely depend on how quickly the Pakistan Business Portal can move from its current design-consultancy stage into working, transaction-processing reality.

CHAPTER 7
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APPENDIX A: LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviation	Full Term
DEEP	Digital Economy Enhancement Project
MoITT	Ministry of Information Technology and Telecommunication
NADRA	National Database and Registration Authority
NITB	National Information Technology Board
BoI	Board of Investment
PBP	Pakistan Business Portal
RLCO	Registration, Licences, Certificates and Other (approvals)
NDEL / NDXL	National Data Exchange Layer
PDA	Pakistan Digital Authority
NDC	National Digital Commission
SOC	Strategic Oversight Committee
PIU / PMU	Project Implementation Unit / Project Management Unit
SEP	Stakeholder Engagement Plan
ESF / ESS10	Environmental and Social Framework / Standard 10 (Stakeholder Engagement)
IDA / IPF	International Development Association / Investment Project Financing
PPRA	Public Procurement Regulatory Authority
ISR	Implementation Status and Results Report
PRMI	Pakistan Regulatory Modernization Initiative
PSW	Pakistan Single Window
ICTA	Islamabad Capital Territory Administration
DRAP	Drug Regulatory Authority of Pakistan
PMBOK	Project Management Body of Knowledge

Table A.1 — List of Abbreviations Used in This Report